

Democracy's Flaws and Virtues: Reflections of Human Nature

“Many forms of government have been tried and will be tried in this world of sin and woe. No one pretends that democracy is perfect or all-wise. Indeed, it has been said that democracy is the worst form of government except all those other forms that have been tried from time to time.”

Winston Churchill, on November 11th, 1947, spoke a few words. The United Kingdom and its allies defeated the oppressive fascist dictatorships of Europe exactly 1 year, 6 months, and 4 days prior. In a few short words, Churchill summed up the flaws and the saving graces of democracy. That day, in the British House of Commons, he said his words. That will always be a characteristic of democracy, as well as people in general. People are flawed, some more than others. Being flawed is part of being human. However, this is where democracy, the personification of the people, saves itself from human flaws: The smart usually stay in power, and the flawed even know when the people in power are too flawed to rule. Thus democracy saves itself. Democracy, like people, is not perfect. The dictators may come to power and overthrow democracy; the military rulers will take over, too. However, the rest of the democratic world will right itself and return to democracy's flawed but self-repairing power. Freedom is a favorite of people, and people are the lifeblood of democracy. Churchill was clearly conveying how democracy is flawed, but so are people, and therefore if any government is both the best and worst of all, it would be a democracy.

Sometimes democracy doesn't work; sometimes dictators take over a supposedly democratic country. This is especially true when times are hard for the people; in times of hardship, people often fall prey to immoral ideas and leaders. Consider the rise and fall of Adolf Hitler. An Austrian painter and disgruntled soldier became the leader of the Nazi Party, joining on July 29, 1921. He became chancellor in 1933 and then dictator. The Weimar Republic became Nazi Germany. What happened to the democracy that was replaced by a fascist dictatorship?

How did a former democracy kill so many people and get away with corrupting an entire country? The answer lies with the people. Poor, unemployed people amid depression, after severe inflation in the 1920s. The Treaty of Versailles was signed by a government that seemed to turn all of Germany's achievements to dust. They had lost a war, were blamed for starting it, were in enormous debt in reparations, and were led by a democracy that couldn't get them out of the Depression. An evil, corrupt, and power-hungry Austrian was able to turn a developing republic into a dictatorship by promising reform, money, and revenge. People are flawed. People do desperate actions in desperate times, but people eventually realize that evil must be stopped. The democracies of France, the United Kingdom, and the United States - with the help of the Soviet Union to work for peace - let Germany lose the war, which in turn led to the rise of the democratic, respected Germany of today. Germany is now a powerful, respected, and prosperous nation that contributes to the world in so many ways that it's impossible to count them all. Democracies, like people, will right themselves back to the ways of peace, freedom, and equality.

Without voices, people could not be free. Democracy is the freedom to be an individual, rather than a cog in the machine of the government. An intellectual, a farmer, a politician, a priest, or a worker all can say what they want, for the most part. As long as it doesn't cause a detriment to some other person, or ruin the strength and truth that is a democracy, anything can be said under a democracy's roof. In North Korea, for example, one man dictates the lives and words of others. He feeds them information that he wants them to hear. No one can say what they want, compared to the increasingly democratic South Korea. One man, the Supreme Leader, named Kim Jong-un, rules an entire country. The state controls what goes to the people. In short, information is controlled, not by the people, but by a man, who, with so much power, is so corrupt. This is a place with no democracy. If freedom is the ability to speak, to debate, to question, to wonder why something is the way it is, and if it could perhaps be improved, then

North Korea does not have it. If it is so important, then why do people let it happen? They don't. In South Korea, the North Korean People's Liberation Front, with defectors from North Korea, is based in Seoul. They await the day when the Kim dynasty of Korea is overthrown so it can become a democratic nation and perhaps, one day, lead to a unified Korea. Thus democracy shows its ability to free itself from oppression, and how freedom will eventually win out over every other government.

Democracy is the people, and the people are a democracy. The people of the United States and the United Kingdom all make themselves heard, and it is that that has led the American nation to rise from a little clump of colonies on the coast of North America into a global superpower. The United Kingdom turned itself from a monarchy, ruled by a bunch of Norwegian Frenchmen, into one where all British citizens are heard and live in liberty. However, The greatest example is that of Japan. When the days of World War II had seen their last, and Japan's red sun had set, democracy returned. The authoritarian, militaristic, encroaching, and imperial power then called the Empire of Japan had been defeated. Democracy had won. When the United States military wrote Japan's constitution, Japan was set to shine. The red sun of Japan is now quite bright: It's an economic powerhouse at the forefront of technology. Its food and culture have been admired the world over. The people are happy and free. That constitution has not been revised once, because the freedoms of the constitution include rights that are unalienable and necessary. Those rights are enough to make sure that they entail are lasting and perfect. The Japanese had rebuilt their island from a war-devastated, bombed state to one that is a respected face of democracy. To think that, like Germany, Japan had been a democratic country at the end of World War I, it would seem that democracy is a powerful force. Democracy always returns; the oppressive government will fall one way or another, and democracy will return to govern the freedom-seeking people. The people will always seek democracy because democracy is power in the people. While power is something that all people are drawn toward, power in the

people allows everyone to be able to speak and be free. It lets people feel like they matter, that they belong. Democracy is power in the people. People are the power of democracy.

People like to say that democracy is the worst form of government. One group says that people are fools, so people can't rule themselves. Power in the people isn't sustainable. Others say that democracy brings some countries to power at the expense of others. America, for example, holds influence over the entire world. However, here's where the power of democracy is eternal: People. People are fools. Some people are more foolish than others. Others don't care that they're fools. The people who lead a country are those who are fools and know it. They are the ones who work with others to make their situation BETTER. As for the oppression of some people, yes, that is true. Some countries in some ways contradict the freedoms that democracy gives them. In the end, it is the people who work for their freedom. People will rise to save themselves from foreign rule, be that a people, a sex, a race, or a nation. People work for freedom, and, with time, people often get that freedom. Democracy adapts.

So democracy is not perfect. It is a flawed institution of flawed individuals leading a bunch of flawed people in a flawed world. However, all these flaws reflect what makes mankind great: the ability to adapt, grow and work for the betterment of all. These flaws are what make people great. Flaws help people be unique. People would not need politics if humans were perfect. That is why democracy, while a flawed system, is the best out of all governments. Its flaws make it whole.

Works Cited

Encyclopedia Britannica. "Adolf Hitler | Biography, Rise to Power, & Facts." *Encyclopedia Britannica*, Encyclopedia Britannica, 15 March 2023,
<https://www.britannica.com/biography/Adolf-Hitler>. Accessed 16 March 2023.

Encyclopedia Britannica. "Japan | History, Flag, Map, Population, & Facts." *Encyclopedia Britannica*, Encyclopedia Britannica, 15 March 2023,
<https://www.britannica.com/place/Japan>. Accessed 16 March 2023.

Encyclopedia Britannica. "Nazi Party | Definition, Meaning, History, & Facts." *Encyclopedia Britannica*, Encyclopedia Britannica, 15 March 2023,
<https://www.britannica.com/topic/Nazi-Party>. Accessed 16 March 2023.

International Churchill Society. "The Worst Form of Government." *International Churchill Society*, International Churchill Society, 2022,
<https://winstonchurchill.org/resources/quotes/the-worst-form-of-government/>. Accessed 16 March 2023.

Yu, Woo-ik , Hahn, Bae-ho , Lew, Young Ick , Lee, Jung Ha and Lee, Chan. "North Korea".
 Encyclopedia Britannica, 16 Mar. 2023, <https://www.britannica.com/place/North-Korea>.
 Accessed 16 March 2023.